divisions within the Afghan Taliban were real and could be capitalised upon. Though Shyam Saran says that, 'the sense was that it is extremely important that in Afghanistan we [India] should make every effort so that the possibility of the Taliban coming back is obviated', Indian policymakers were acutely aware of their limitations to contain the Taliban's resurgence.[31] If the coalition military juggernaut failed at the task, no other country, or group of countries, would be able to achieve that in the short and medium term, and especially not using military means. In such a scenario, outside the media's glare, Indian officials started debating the merits of engaging with select sections of the Afghan Taliban and Hekmatyar (with whom India had a history of covert engagement). The consulates helped in facilitating such engagement that led to policy learning. Apart from monitoring the distribution of India's developmental aid and scholarships, the consulates became intelligence outposts that were meant to monitor Pakistan's activities in Afghanistan, and to harness political differences between the Afghan Taliban and Pakistan. As Sahgal articulated, 'apart from the soft power, there was a concerted effort made [by India] to penetrate the south and the east [of Afghanistan]. In Kabul, Kandahar, Jalalabad, and [in] all those areas, the consulates were opened up. The main job of the consulates was to keep track of what the Pakistani activities are. And this is the time [when] the Pakistanis started objecting and started making a hue and cry'.[32] Sameer Patil, Assistant Director at the JIC (2008–13), confirms Sahgal's point: 'In Afghanistan our [Indian intelligence] assets were everywhere, and we were able to get a good sense of what is happening'.[33]

Leave or die

Tipped off in advance by the Afghan and US intelligence services, India had been preparing for a big attack on its embassy in Kabul. HESCO barriers were set up outside the embassy compound and a 24x7 security team made of ITBP soldiers and Afghan guards were deployed on high alert.[34] But when Hamza Shakoor rammed a car laden with 100kg explosives into the HESCO barriers at 8.30 AM on 7 July 2008, the vibrations shook Kabul and beyond. Fifty-eight people, mostly Afghan, were killed, and 141 were injured.[35] Among the dead were Indian